

EUROPEAN NATION STATES

PLANNING PEACE FOR A CONTINENT AT WAR

Europe at the dawn of the 19th century bore little resemblance to the peaceful political unit of cooperative countries that it has become in the 21st century. Indeed, prior to 1815, the power balances and political alliances were constantly shifting, leading to near-continual confrontation.

The Napoleonic Wars had seen Europe in a cycle of almost constant conflict for more than a decade and left Europe in a state of imbalance. To address the questions of how to reorganize the war-ravaged continent, a congress was called at Vienna in 1814. Decisions were made on what to do with the new states that Napoleon had created, such as the Grand Duchy of Warsaw (see map below), and the regions of Germany, Italy, and the Low Countries that had been annexed to France. The peacemakers aimed to avoid a repetition of the conflicts that had

torn Europe apart and a spirit of conservatism and restoration prevailed—though not all deposed rulers were restored, and not all possessions lost in the Napoleonic Wars were regained.

The national boundaries resulting from the Treaty of Vienna in 1815 stayed in place for more than four decades. Fear of revolution led to a desire among Europe's statesmen to maintain the status quo. Although there were threats from liberal and nationalist elements, the Vienna system survived and disputes were largely settled by diplomacy.

NAPOLEONIC EMPIRE

When Napoleon became First Consul of France in 1799, he soon made clear his imperial ambitions by crowning himself emperor of France in 1804 and mounting military campaigns throughout Europe.

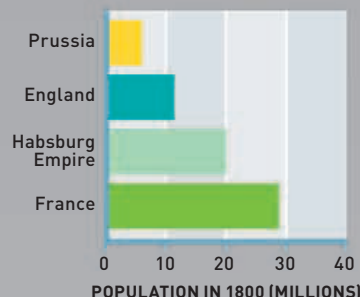


1812 Since coming to power in 1799, Napoleon had managed to extend France's power in Europe dramatically, controlling the Low Countries, parts of Germany and Italy, Spain, and Poland, although his attempts to encroach on Russia were met with a humiliating defeat in 1812.

KEY
■ French territory ruled directly from Paris 1812
■ Dependent state 1812

1815 The Congress of Vienna's reorganization of Europe led to the creation of the German Confederation. The growth of liberalism and nationalism in Europe saw uprisings across the continent but the Vienna system held firm until the revolutions of 1848.

KEY
✶ Threat to Vienna system
--- Internal frontiers 1815
— German confederation



Population chart
 At the beginning of Napoleon's rule, France had a far larger population than the surrounding states. This chart shows population figures c. 1800.

2,000,000
 NATIVE FRENCH SOLDIERS
 1804–15

1,000,000
 CASUALTIES
 1804–15

French forces
 Over the course of the Napoleonic Wars, soldiers from all over the French Empire fought, and died, in Napoleon's army. At its height, it comprised nearly 600,000 men.



200
 THE NUMBER OF STATES REPRESENTED AT THE VIENNA CONGRESS